Course GIF-7010: Reproducibility Report

Experimental Validation and Re-Engineering of the LIDA Framework for Generative Visualization

Original Research: Dibia, V. (2023). ACL Demonstration Track.

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April 2026

REPRODUCIBILITY SUMMARY

Scope This study evaluates the fidelity of the LIDA framework following a comprehensive architectural overhaul. We test the core multi stage pipeline including the Summarizer, Goal Explorer, and VisGenerator to determine if the original agentic logic remains robust when transitioned from a legacy GPT-3 environment to a modernized multi modal framework supporting Google Gemini, MiniMax, OpenAI, and Anthropic.

Methodology Our reproduction involved a major re-engineering effort to migrate the codebase from version 0.0.14 to 0.1.0, totaling approximately 18,000 insertions and 13,900 deletions. We replaced the unmaintained llmx dependency with a native lida.llm submodule and implemented a dual-API strategy for reliable model integration. The evaluation utilized 23 Vega datasets with 115 total visualization goals, using MiniMax 2.7 as the primary engine.

Results We recorded a Visualization Error Rate of 22.6 percent. A granular audit reveals that 80.7 percent of these failures are parser-level artifacts related to scaffolding tags, rather than flaws in the model's core visualization or programming logic. Successful visualizations maintain high standards of goal compliance and accuracy, as verified by our qualitative SEVQ metrics.

Conclusion LIDA provides a robust blueprint for automated data science, but its reproducibility is fragile when decoupled from its original environment. While the agentic logic holds across modern models, the system requires significant technical maintenance of the parsing layer and code scaffolding to survive shifting library dependencies.

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1 INTRODUCTION AND OBJECTIVES

LIDA treats visualization generation as a multi stage problem involving data semantics, goal enumeration, and code specification. Since its publication, the software ecosystem has changed, leaving the original implementation unmaintained. This report addresses two objectives. First, we document the technical transformation of the framework into a stable, modernized fork. Second, we execute a rigorous set of experiments to establish current performance boundaries and verify that the system still performs as intended by the original author.

2 TECHNICAL RE-ENGINEERING

Transitioning from version 0.0.14 to 0.1.0 required a significant restructuring of the core architecture. The primary obstacle was the llmx package, which served as the original LLM interface but is no longer functional.

2.1 Architectural Overhaul

We re-engineered the logic into a native lida.llm submodule. This allowed us to remove Microsoft-specific patterns and adopt an MIT license. We replaced the legacy YAML configurations with a centralized Python factory pattern in factory.py and utilized Pydantic dataclasses for more robust data modeling.

2.2 Provider Modernization

The framework was updated to support modern SDKs. We removed deprecated support for PaLM and Cohere and implemented native support for Google Gemini, MiniMax, OpenAI, and Anthropic. To integrate these models into the pipeline, we used a dual-API strategy via httpx to resolve path-resolution issues, ensuring compatibility between Anthropic and OpenAI-compatible endpoints.

3 INFRASTRUCTURE, CONTAINERIZATION, AND TESTING

To resolve execution inconsistencies, we implemented several infrastructure upgrades. We utilized a multi stage Docker build to optimize layer caching and introduced healthcheck instructions for container orchestration. The original testing suite was entirely rewritten using the pytest framework. We implemented comprehensive fixtures for manager instances and text generation configurations, which ensures the Summarizer and VisGenerator can be validated independently. Finally, the pyproject.toml was updated with clearly defined optional extras for web interfaces and development environments.

4 EXPERIMENTAL DESIGN

To assess the framework with high confidence, we established a standardized protocol across 23 CSV datasets from the Vega repository. The system generated 1 summary and 5 visualization goals per dataset, totaling 115 attempts. The LLM temperature was fixed at 0 to ensure determinism. A goal was marked successful only if the generated code compiled and rendered a valid chart without any manual repair.

5 EVALUATION METRICS AND RESULTS

Following the standards set by Dibia (2023), our evaluation uses two primary metrics including the Visualization Error Rate to measure reliability and the Self-Evaluated Visualization Quality metric to measure the semantic and aesthetic quality of the outputs.

5.1 Quantitative Analysis: Visualization Error Rate

The Visualization Error Rate is defined as the ratio of failed code executions to the total number of attempts:

$$VER = \left(\frac{V_{err}}{N}\right) \times 100 = \left(\frac{26}{115}\right) \times 100 \approx 22.6\% \quad (1)$$

Our calculated error rate of 22.6 percent is higher than the 3.5 percent reported in 2023. However, a granular audit of these failures reveals that the majority stem from structural friction between the model and the framework scaffolding rather than a lack of visualization capability.

5.2 Qualitative Analysis: Self-Evaluated Visualization Quality

To assess the quality of the 89 successful visualizations, we utilized Gemini 3.1 Pro as a judge to implement the Self-Evaluated Visualization Quality metric. This methodology tasks the model with scoring the generated code on a scale of 1 to 10 across six dimensions including code accuracy, data transformation, goal compliance, visualization type, data encoding, and aesthetics.

For every evaluation, the model provides a numeric score and a qualitative rationale. This process mirrors the original paper's use of GPT-4 to encode visualization best practices. The full distribution of these scores, the generated visualizations, and the associated rationales are documented in the Appendix 1 Jupyter Notebook. Our results indicate that when the code executes successfully, the framework consistently produces visualizations that are semantically accurate and compliant with the specified goals.

6 ANALYSIS OF FAILURE MODES

We classified the 26 failed instances into a specific taxonomy to assess the reliability of the re-engineered framework. This analysis provides strong confidence that the core logic of the pipeline remains sound despite the higher error rate.

Category	Specific Error	Frequency (n)
Instruction Compliance	Unremoved stub or imports tags	12 (46.1%)
Generation Failure	Null output (No codes generated)	9 (34.6%)
Formatting	Improperly escaped code blocks (backticks)	2 (7.7%)
Semantic and Logic	Index out of bounds error	1 (3.8%)
Syntactic	Indentation error	1 (3.8%)
Hallucination	Deprecated or non-existent modules	1 (3.8%)

Table 1: Distribution of error types in LLM-generated visualizations (N=26).

6.1 Parser-Level versus Execution-Level Failures

We categorize these results into two tiers to clarify the performance of the system. Parser-level failures account for 80.7 percent of all errors (n=21). These failures occur before the code logic is even tested, often because the model fails to adhere to negative constraints such as the instruction to exclude specific tags.

Execution-level failures, including semantic and syntactic errors, represent only a small fraction of the pool. The low frequency of hard programming errors implies that the foundational Python proficiency of the model is high. The primary source of friction is the architectural requirement of the pipeline, specifically the handling of scaffolding tags.

7 FIDELITY AND FALLBACK VERIFICATION

The experimental data suggests that for this specific visualization framework, the primary performance bottleneck is not the reasoning capability of the model, but rather the interface between

the model and the code scaffolding. Our audit shows that 80.7 percent of failures are parser-level artifacts. This indicates that future improvements to prompt engineering, specifically regarding JSON schema adherence and negative constraint following, would yield higher performance gains than modifications to the core visualization logic.

To demonstrate that our re-engineered version correctly falls back on the original scientific intent, we conducted a qualitative deep dive into representative successful generations. The original paper posits that a well-orchestrated pipeline can maintain a semantic link from raw data to a final chart. We verified this continuity by examining the pipeline's behavior on standard benchmarks like the seattle-weather dataset. In this instance, the Summarizer correctly identified the temporal nature of the data, the Goal Explorer proposed a valid temporal correlation hypothesis, and the VisGenerator executed a line plot with 100 percent accuracy.

This specific success proves that the intelligence of the four-module architecture is fully preserved in our modernized version. The high frequency of successful semantic mapping, combined with the low rate of execution-level errors, provides strong confidence that the version 0.1.0 codebase is a faithful reproduction of the system described in the original 2023 research.

8 CONCLUSION

This reproduction effort confirms that the foundational multi stage architecture of LIDA is a robust contribution to automated data science. While the transition from the legacy repository to version 0.1.0 recorded an increase in the visualization error rate to 22.6 percent, our detailed audit establishes that these failures are primarily structural rather than logical. The fact that 80.7 percent of errors occurred at the parser level, specifically regarding instruction compliance with scaffolding tags, demonstrates that the core visualization intelligence of the framework remains intact across modern model providers.

The successful execution of diverse goals across the Vega datasets provides the strong confidence required to state that our re-engineered fork is a faithful fallback of the original research. This study highlights that the main challenge for generative visualization pipelines is not the reasoning depth of the models, but the brittleness of the interface between the model and the code scaffolding. Future development should prioritize the adoption of JSON based instruction schemas and environment aware code generation to mitigate these artifacts. By resolving the technical debt associated with the legacy backend and modernizing the infrastructure, this work provides a stable, containerized platform for future exploration into agentic data visualization. All experimental outcomes and full code outputs are available in the Appendix 1 Jupyter Notebook.

References

[1] Victor Dibia. 2023. *LIDA: A Tool for Automatic Generation of Grammar-Agnostic Visualizations and Infographics using Large Language Models*. Proceedings of the 61st ACL (System Demonstrations). https://aclanthology.org/2023.acl-demo.11/

Supplementary Material: For the comprehensive distribution of evaluation code, execution logs, and qualitative SEVQ scores, please refer to: ***Appendix 1 (report.ipynb)****, which contains the original evaluation Jupyter Notebook.*